Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

   You mean, when we are just reaching here or how things are now? In the early years, things were easy because we had food stamp. We used to go and buy everything you need, and you could not run out. But now, things are hard because we must use our money to buy everything, and things are very expensive.

   Follow up: Who helped you apply for food stamp?

   I don't know. Because, when I reached here, Mohammed have us the food stamp. I was still new, so and he brought he card to me. But now that it's closed, I went to CCS to ask them, and they told me that it's closed, and they can't give me another one.

   Follow up: Who is Mohammed? Is he your caseworker?

   Yes.

   Follow up: You mentioned that you don't have food stamp now, did you try to re-apply for it?

   No, when I was getting sick many times, I went to CCS to apply for Medicaid and asked about food stamp, but they told me that they cannot give them to me because I am working now.

   Follow up: How long were you on food stamp?

   Maybe around 5 months. They closed it even before I started working.

   Follow up: So, you never tried to reapply for food stamp on your own, you were just told by CCS that you they can't give it to you?

   How can I reapply when I don't know where to go and how to do it? When they told me that they can't give it to me, there's nothing else I could do. I have tried to see how I can reapply because life is hard now, even without Medicaid and my sickness, but I don't know where to go.

   Follow up: Did your caseworker not teach you how to reapply for food stamp?

   No, he never taught me how to do it. He even never enrolled me in school.

   a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

Food became less because sometimes, you go and do groceries, and food stamp is finished, then you don't get enough food. Sometimes, I could spend a week without food because food stamp was finished.

Follow up: What about now that you are working?

This time when I started working, at least but things are still hard because I have to pay rent. I make $15 per hour, have to pay rent, buy medicines, and other things. So, things are still hard, but at least now. We can't get money to buy enough food.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

I tried to see if I can get food because there's where I went to get treatment and they said that if you need food, you can be getting some food like once a month. But then when I called their phone number, they never picked. So, I never got the free food.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

I cannot say that CCS helped me.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

Nothing that they helped me with. What I can say that they help was to take me to the hospital to get checked, but even now, I haven't received the results.

ii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Yes, I can find. Because even though I'm with them, they don't really help me with anything. If I have that assistance, I can find it.

Follow up: Did they teach you how to apply for benefits like food stamp?

No, they never taught me how to apply. They never helped me with anything.

iii. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

Yes, I would like to learn how to apply for benefits like food stamp, Medicaid and other things to help me in life.

iv. You indicated that you have used SNAP program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

I cannot know, because when I reached here, it's the caseworker that gave us food stamp.

v. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

When I had food stamp, I never lacked food. But I was only with it for 5 months.

Follow up: When you had food stamp, how did you see it. Can you please explain.

When I had it, I bought everything I needed except the nonfood items like soap.

vi. Tell me about the food you received from them.

All the food that I needed including juice.

vii. What % of your foods come from this program?

100% when I had it but now, I don't have it, so 0%.

2. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
    a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

    We like potatoes because it's what we were used of eating. Beans, etc. We find all of them.

    b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

    Not at all, but I see cabbage in all stores. I also see spinach in all stores like Smiths, Walmart and Chinese stores.

    c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?
        i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

        There's nothing that CCS helped me with.

    d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

    Yes, we are using it now because they are open.

    e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?
        i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

        I don't think I know it.

        Follow up: Is there anything else you would like to share with us like how CCS helped you regarding buying food and applying for food stamp?

        At the beginning, things were easy because they had given me food stamp. I tried and things were easier a little bit. But now things are hard because I don't have food stamp and Medicaid, because of my income, when I must pay rent, buy medicine and other things. Things like these are hard for me because of the challenge of money. When I had food stamp, things were a little easier. Now, its hard. Paying rent, getting medical care, buying food; now it's hard.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

    What prohibits them, the first thing is that the programs that give free food, they give you food that we are not used of. Even if they give you the food and tell you how to cook it, you do it but find that it did not turn out the way you expected. This prohibits us from getting the food again. It's like the way someone can give you red water when you are used of white water. So, this prohibits us a lot.

    Follow up: So, they usually give you food that's not your cultural food or the food you are not used of eating?

Yes.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

   My thoughts, given the fact that life is hard here, if they can give us like small gardens, so we can grow our vegetables, that can help us.

   Follow up: Is there anything else you would like to add here?

   What to add here, I think if they can also make a group where people can be contributing money together and help those in need.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

   Maybe if they can be finding those people in need, depending on their situation, then they help them like giving them food stamp, helping them get medical care. These things can make it easier on those refugees that are struggling a lot. Many of us, the main challenge we have is not getting medical care, and enough food. But if they can be helping those who don't have medical care and food, those things can make life easier for us.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   Personally, I think what can improve food security in refugees is farming. Offering gardens to people, where they can farm, put food in storage and use it when needed, those things can help us a lot.